Starting a business in Switzerland

Permission, business structure, insurance and tax questions to resolve before your first order.

01 / Permission to operate

- [ ] Confirm whether my residence document permits self-employment and which cantonal procedure applies.
- [ ] Prepare an activity description, customer profile and evidence of a workable business plan.
- [ ] Check professional licences and qualification-recognition requirements.

02 / Structure and registration

- [ ] Compare a sole proprietorship and GmbH for liability, costs and accounting.
- [ ] Clarify business registration and recognition of self-employment by the compensation office.
- [ ] Check whether commercial-register entry is required for my structure and circumstances.

03 / Finance and insurance

- [ ] Plan startup costs, running expenses and a reserve for the first months.
- [ ] Clarify tax duties, VAT treatment and an appropriate bookkeeping process.
- [ ] Check social insurance, health coverage and liability protection.

04 / Before your first order

- [ ] Define the service, price, extra costs and payment schedule.
- [ ] Prepare written terms, invoicing and cancellation conditions.
- [ ] Find cantonal startup advice and a relevant business community.

Check the current requirements

This is a planning checklist. Requirements depend on status, activity and place of residence. Confirm your circumstances with the responsible authority. Boxes can be checked in the PDF.

ch.ch — moving to Switzerland

KMU Portal — setting up a business

KMU Portal — self-employment formalities

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My questions and next step

01 / Contact / question / next action

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